

GROWING BIG ON TECH

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Across its businesses, Mukesh Ambani-led Reliance Industries—India’s largest company by market cap—is harnessing the digital medium and technology to boost productivity and make it future-ready

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN • PHOTO BY BANDEEP SINGH



WHEN RELIANCE INDUSTRIES Ltd (RIL) launched its Jio mobile telephony service in September 2016, it was like a cyclone making landfall. Existing rivals had no strategy (read: money) to stand before its initial free-for-six-months offer or its astute decision to go for a nationwide launch of the latest 4G VoLTE. The rivals were stuck with 3G, for which they had paid a bomb to get spectrum, or still testing 4G VoLTE in pockets.

Then, at the commercial launch in March

2017, when the “free” period ended, Jio offered rock-bottom tariffs for data. All this for the convenience of pre-paid connections, meaning no fixed monthly rentals. (Jio launched its first post-paid service only in June 2021.)

It was a rout.

RIL had been putting together a strategy for the group’s second entry into telecom for quite some time. It was fascinated by the story of China, where China Mobile